

## Form

### Simple Past

irregular verbs: see 2nd column of irregular verbs

Example:

I spoke

regular verbs: infinitive + ed

Example:

I worked

### Exceptions

#### Exceptions when adding 'ed':

- when the final letter is *e*, only add *d*

Example:

love - loved

- after a short, stressed vowel, the final consonant is doubled

Example:

admit - admitted

- final *l* is always doubled in British English (not in American English)

Example:

travel - travelled

- after a consonant, final *y* becomes *i* (but: not after a vowel)

Example:

worry - worried

but: play - played

### Present Perfect Simple

irregular verbs: form of 'have' + 3rd column of irregular verbs

Example:

I / you / we / they have spoken

he / she / it has spoken

regular verbs: form of 'have' + infinitive + ed

Example:

I / you / we / they have worked

he / she / it has worked

## Use

In British English, the use of Simple Past and Present Perfect is quite strict. As soon as a time expression in the past is given, you have to use Simple Past. If there are no signal words, you must decide if we just talk about an action in the past or if its consequence in the present is important.

Note that the following explanations and exercises refer to **British English** only. In American English, you can normally use Simple Past instead of Present Perfect. We cannot accept this

in our exercises, however, as this would lead to confusions amongst those who have to learn the differences.

### **Certain time in the past or *just / already / yet*?**

Do you want to express that an action happened at a certain time in the past (even if it was just a few seconds ago) or that an action has *just / already / not yet* happened?

**Simple Past**  
**certain time in the past**

Example:  
I phoned Mary 2 minutes ago.

**Present Perfect Simple**  
***just / already / not yet***

Example:  
I have just phoned Mary.

### **Certain event in the past or how often so far?**

Do you want to express when a certain action took place or whether / how often an action has happened till now?

**Simple Past**  
**certain event in the past**

Example:  
He went to Canada last summer.

**Present Perfect Simple**  
***whether / how often till now***

Example:  
Have you ever been to Canada? / I have been to Canada twice.

### **Emphasis on action or result?**

Do you just want to express what happened in the past? Or do you want to emphasise the result (a past action's consequence in the present)?

**Simple Past**  
**Emphasis on action**

Example:  
I bought a new bike. (*just telling what I did in the past.*)

**Present Perfect Simple**  
**Emphasis on result**

Example:  
I have bought a new bike. (*With this sentence I actually want to express that I have a new bike now.*)

### **Signal Words**

**Simple Past**

- yesterday
- ... ago
- in 1990
- the other day
- last ...

**Present Perfect Simple**

- just
- already
- up to now
- until now / till now
- ever
- (not) yet
- so far/ lately / recently